

COMMUNITY

TEXT: Acts 2:41-47 (NKJV) *“Then those who gladly received his word were baptized; and that day about three thousand souls were added to them. 42 And they continued steadfastly in the apostles’ doctrine and fellowship, in the breaking of bread, and in prayers. 43 Then fear came upon every soul, and many wonders and signs were done through the apostles. 44 Now all who believed were together, and had all things in common, 45 and sold their possessions and goods, and divided them among all, as anyone had need. 46 So continuing daily with one accord in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, they ate their food with gladness and simplicity of heart, 47 praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord added to the church daily those who were being saved.”*

INTRO: The book of Acts is less than one chapter old before the Bible speaks of the structure of the First Century Church. Here we are introduced to a church model that included:

- Corporate worship...
- Bearing the burdens of one another...
- Fellowshiping from house to house...

The model of the First Century Church included a component of community. The word “*Community*” is derived from Latin to French to our English word that basically means “*Things held in common*” or “*Common unity*”.

A community is generally a group of people who have:

- Shared beliefs...
- Shared government...
- Shared culture... (Ways of doing life together)
- Shared heritage... (We are one in Christ)

- Shared interests... (Our goals are to Disciple, Empower & serve)

Some examples of community, we might refer to:

- African-American community...
- Hispanic community...
- Asian community...
- Business community...

We are a Christian Community! We come from a diversity of backgrounds yet share beliefs, government, culture, heritage and interests.

The biggest need in the modern church is developing and facilitating a structure that allows people to do life together.

BIBLICAL REASONS FOR CREATING COMMUNITY THROUGH LIFE GROUPS

Jesus ministered to the multitudes (preaching, healing, providing food) but He disciplined the disciples in small groups.

Jesus and the early church demonstrated for us the power and effectiveness of Christian community. I believe, the church that successfully adopts the New Testament pattern of community without sacrificing its Pentecostalism will become powerful and effective force for the last day's. (What would happen to the church if we were forbidden to ever meet for corporate worship again?)

Matthew 9:35-38 (NKJV) ***“Then Jesus went about all the cities and villages, teaching in their synagogues, preaching the gospel of the kingdom, and healing every sickness and every disease among the people. ³⁶ But when He saw the multitudes, He was moved with compassion for them, because they were weary and scattered, like sheep having no shepherd.***

³⁷ Then He said to His disciples, “The harvest

truly is plentiful, but the laborers are few.
³⁸ Therefore pray the Lord of the harvest to send out laborers into His harvest.”

In the Jesus church model the corporate gathering served a purpose and was deemed very valuable. But notice, “*He was moved with compassion*” because they were “*Weary and scattered*” because of the lack of “*Shepherds.*”

The bottom line is that Jesus taught and met the needs of the multitudes but His long-range plan to care for them, was to provide them with trained shepherds – The Twelve Disciples.

Please know, the importance of the corporate gathering at CT will remain in tact but we **MUST** find a way to provide a higher level of shepherding. We believe that demands a strong life group ministry where people shepherd (Disciple) people.

The fact is, Jesus created a Life Group to train those shepherds. Mark 3:13-14 (NKJV) ***“He went up on the mountain and called to Him those He Himself wanted. And they came to Him. 14 Then He appointed twelve, that they might be with Him and that He might send them out to preach.”*** Pay special attention to that point – ***“That they might BE WITH HIM.”***

Jesus’ first meeting with the disciples was a home fellowship – John 1:39 (NKJV) ***“They came and saw where He was staying, and remained with Him that day ...”***

In His first encounter with those who would become His disciples, Jesus didn’t take them to the Temple or the Synagogue to minister to them. He brought them to His house.

Also, He used the “small group” concept to teach and mentor them . Mark 4:34 (NKJV)

“But without a parable He did not speak to them (crowds). And when they were alone, He explained all things to His disciples.”

According to Acts 2, the church of the first century (before the persecution) met on regular basis in the temple and in the houses. After the persecution and destruction of the temple they continued meeting but they did so in houses. Because of this, the Christian community not only survived, it thrived!

Historical facts:

The people of Israel were divided into tribes, leaders of thousands, hundreds, and tens in order to help them fulfill the law and take care of the relational issues.

During the exile, the Israelites who were far from Jerusalem created the synagogues. Synagogues were small centers of religious teaching, social interactions and educational

activities. The minimum number of members was ten.

In Jesus' times, discipleship in small groups was a very common practice among the Jewish and gentiles audiences. It was the way to develop disciples and transfer the DNA from person-to-person and from generation-to-generation.

Even when Jesus spent a lot of time with the multitudes, he spent more time with the seventy and even more time with the twelve. Jesus preached to the multitudes but to the seventy and especially the twelve, Jesus explained His teachings in great detail, and took the time to deal with their personal issues. The time He spent with the seventy and the twelve increased significantly in the six months prior to his crucifixion.

The First Century Church received the instructions from Jesus to become witnesses in Jerusalem, all of Judea, Samaria, and to the

uttermost parts of the earth. After they received the Holy Spirit they set up shop in Jerusalem and stayed right there until the persecution started. Staying in Jerusalem and having church was easy but it was not what they had been instructed to do.

During this time there was addition but not multiplication. They even had the need to implement structures in order to facilitate that growth (Acts 6:1-7 Deacons). After the death of Stephen the Bible says ***“At that time a great persecution arose against the church which was at Jerusalem; and they were all scattered throughout the regions of Judea and Samaria.”*** It looks like they needed to be persecuted in order to fulfill Jesus’ instruction to go to the uttermost parts of the earth.

Beginning with the persecution, houses became the place where the Christians had “church.”

In the New Testament’s vocabulary, the word “church” almost always refers to the gathering

of Christians in a house. There are twenty six references in the New Testament that talk about believers meeting in homes, or being part of a household.

In the year 70 the temple in Jerusalem was destroyed and it wasn't until the year 150 when Christians were able to meet again in a place (not an official temple) dedicated to worship. There was an eighty year stretch where there was not a church building as we know them.

In the year 312, the Roman emperor Constantine (the first “Christian” emperor) established Christianity as the official religion of the Empire (Catholic Church). As a result of this he built temples and let the Christians gather in public. Most of the Christians stopped meeting in houses and started attending “church” where there was a “professional minister” who was the only one authorized to teach the Bible.

Believe it or not, this ushered the Christian church into its darkest, most powerless, ineffective era ever. The church lost the ministry of the believers (Body of Christ) and became a religious/political institution.

In 1500 Martin Luther (Protestant Reformation) brought the Bible back to the Christians (in their own language) and confronted the corrupted church, BUT he didn't change the "temple centered" paradigm.

In 1700 John Wesley was the first evangelical minister who organized the new believers (disciples) into "classes" in order to help them walk out their faith. John Wesley is the father of small group ministry.

In our era the healthiest and growing churches have Small Groups as a vital part of their structures. They are not churches with small groups; they are small group churches.

Moving toward small groups is simply getting us back to the original blueprint of history's most successful church – The First Century Church!

APPLICATION

(Discuss the needs observed at CT|Church over recent years – Most of the people who have left hand done so because they did not get connected)

(Discuss the process staff went through to analyze the need and find solutions)

(Discuss the arrival at revisiting the simple, powerful system of Jesus and the New Testament Church)

(Discuss the process going forward for CT|Church and its Life Groups)

PRACTICAL REASONS FOR CREATING COMMUNITY THROUGH LIFE GROUPS

Acts 2:41-47 (NKJV) *“Then those who gladly received his word were baptized; and that day about three thousand souls were added to them. 42 And they continued steadfastly in the apostles’ doctrine and fellowship, in the breaking of bread, and in prayers. 43 Then fear came upon every soul, and many wonders and signs were done through the apostles. 44 Now all who believed were together, and had all things in common, 45 and sold their possessions and goods, and divided them among all, as anyone had need. 46 So continuing daily with one accord in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, they ate their food with gladness and simplicity of heart, 47 praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord added to the church daily those who were being saved.”* Last week we learned that within the first one hundred years the First Century Church

had evangelized the known world without the use of church buildings.

There is a big difference in a pastor centric church and a community (Body of believers) centric church. If we do not delegate the shepherding of the church the pastors will wear themselves out and it will be unhealthy for the people. Jesus recognized this and took steps to correct it. Matthew 9:35-38 (NKJV) “*Then*

Jesus went about all the cities and villages, teaching in their synagogues, preaching the gospel of the kingdom, and healing every sickness and every disease among the people.

³⁶ *But when He saw the multitudes, He was moved with compassion for them, because they were weary and scattered, like sheep having no shepherd.* ³⁷ *Then He said to His disciples, “The harvest truly is plentiful, but the laborers are few. ³⁸ Therefore pray the Lord of the harvest to send out laborers into His harvest.”*

You only have to look to Moses and the Children of Israel to discover the disfunction of a pastor centric church. Exodus 18:13-27

(NKJV) *“And so it was, on the next day, that Moses sat to judge the people; and the people stood before Moses from morning until evening. 14 So when Moses’ father-in-law saw all that he did for the people, he said, “What is this thing that you are doing for the people? Why do you alone sit, and all the people stand before you from morning until evening?”*

15 And Moses said to his father-in-law, “Because the people come to me to inquire of God. 16 When they have a difficulty, they come to me, and I judge between one and another; and I make known the statutes of God and His laws.” 17 So Moses’ father-in-law said to him, “The thing that you do is not good. 18 Both you and these people who are with you will surely wear yourselves out. For this thing is too much for you; you are not able to perform it by yourself. 19 Listen now to my voice; I will give you counsel, and God will be with you:

Stand before God for the people, so that you may bring the difficulties to God. 20 And you shall teach them the statutes and the laws, and show them the way in which they must walk and the work they must do. 21 Moreover you shall select from all the people able men, such as fear God, men of truth, hating covetousness; and place such over them to be rulers of thousands, rulers of hundreds, rulers of fifties, and rulers of tens. 22 And let them judge the people at all times. Then it will be that every great matter they shall bring to you, but every small matter they themselves shall judge. So it will be easier for you, for they will bear the burden with you. 23 If you do this thing, and God so commands you, then you will be able to endure, and all this people will also go to their place in peace.” 24 So Moses heeded the voice of his father-in-law and did all that he had said. 25 And Moses chose able men out of all Israel, and made them heads over the people: rulers of thousands, rulers of hundreds, rulers of fifties, and rulers of tens.

26 So they judged the people at all times; the hard cases they brought to Moses, but they judged every small case themselves.”

Shepherding a large group of believers requires delegating the responsibilities of shepherding. The New-Testament model is one of mentoring and delegation. Ephesians 4:11-16 (NKJV) ***“He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers, 12 for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ, 13 till we all come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ; 14 that we should no longer be children, tossed to and fro and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the trickery of men, in the cunning craftiness of deceitful plotting, 15 but, speaking the truth in love, may grow up in all things into Him who is the head—Christ— 16 from whom the whole body, joined and knit***

together by what every joint supplies, according to the effective working by which every part does its share, causes growth of the body for the edifying of itself in love.” The proper role of ministers: Equipping

The church that organizes itself around the biblical principle of Life Groups will have energized leaders and growing and energized members.

In Moses' previous model (Most churches operate in this model) there is great potential for the leader to begin to lead poorly – because of fatigue. There is great potential in this model for the pastor to fail of his priestly duties

The Biblical role of a pastor is for the pastor to:

- Pray and seek the face of God...
- Teach the truths of the Word of God...
- Receive revelation from God...
- Project the vision for the church...
- Equip the people to do everything else...

It is very important for the pastors and the people to embrace the Biblical role of the pastor and the believers. Everyone stay in their lane.

Ten reasons why life (small) groups are vital for a healthy-growing church:

- Personal discovery... Personal discovery happens in small groups better than large

groups for a number of reasons. You can learn, ask questions, involve yourself in the lives of others, and generally make yourself vulnerable among other people who are doing the same in small groups. You just can't do that in a corporate gathering designed for worship and preaching.

- Smaller communities are more effective... Smaller communities function more like, communities. That may seem like a given, but the bigger the group is, the less like community it feels. The kind of community I am advocating requires a level of intimacy easily lost as numbers grow. You simply cannot know everyone beyond a certain point, and you certainly will not open up about your struggles and sins in a large group of people you don't know.
- Deeper Friendships... Small groups deliver deeper friendships that double as accountability. When people know you, really know you, your life becomes far more transparent, including your sin. Others learn

to read you and will call you out for those sins, creating opportunities to deal with real life difficulties as they surface. This is part of what we should expect from good friends. This provides a real feeling of being part of God's family.

- Maximum participation... Small groups deliver maximum participation. There are opportunities to discuss the issues with others in the church. Life issues can be discussed openly among trusted friends. Mission can be planned out and participated in together. Lives are sharpened and leaders developed. Small groups are an absolute necessity for involving as many people as possible in the life and ministry of your church.
- Better understanding of the Bible... Preaching and teaching are one-way communication. People listen while the speaker speaks. This model is fine for imparting knowledge but not as effective for personal application as a small group. In a

small group setting, people can ask questions, participate in a discussion of the text, and hear others share insights and illustrations of the truth you are trying to grasp. The Bible must be applied to one's own personal situations and that happens best in small groups.

- Provides a comfortable introduction for nonbelievers to the Christian faith...
Inviting people to the church is, very often, intimidating to believers as well as for non-believers. Inviting someone instead to a small group meeting provides a non-threatening way for a believer to get a non-believer into a community of faith. It is here that the non-believer is brought face-to-face with the reality of the difference between the converted and unregenerate life. They begin to see believers live out their faith, pray for one another, share God's word, give testimony of God's work in their lives. Small groups are a powerful missional tool

that allows for a more natural spread of the gospel among nonbelievers.

- Provides an ideal way to care for the needs of people within the church. When one believer in a small group is struggling financially, emotionally, spiritually, socially, etc., it is much easier for the members of the group to notice and provide help.
- Provide a way for Christians to live out their faith instead of merely hearing more preaching or teaching. If Sunday morning is for listening, then the rest of the week is for living. Whether it's discussing the Sunday sermon, talking about a spiritual battle, or simply praying for one another, small groups create a context for Christians to live out their faith in real life.
- Provides a source of encouragement and accountability. It's easy to slip in and out of church unnoticed. It's not just mega churches where this happens. In an average-sized church of 100 or 150, people may be coming to each Sunday service, but not

getting involved. These people may need accountability in their lives, encouragement in their walk with God, or help in some way. Small groups provide a way to better meet these needs.

- Energy and synergy is created when people learn to care for each other on a more personal level

The pastor can only be in one place at one time. Even Jesus could not be in more than one place at one time during His ministry. This is why He trained leaders (Twelve Disciples) and sent the Holy Spirit.

APPLICATION

(Discuss the needs observed at CT|Church over recent years)

(Discuss the process staff went through to analyze the need and find solutions)

(Discuss the arrival at revisiting the simple, powerful system of Jesus and the New Testament Church)

(Discuss the process going forward for CT| Church and its Life Groups)

THE PATH TO ACHIEVING CORPORATE VISION IS THROUGH LIFE GROUPS

Acts 2:41-47 (NKJV) *“Then those who gladly received his word were baptized; and that day about three thousand souls were added to them. 42 And they continued steadfastly in the apostles’ doctrine and fellowship, in the breaking of bread, and in prayers. 43 Then fear came upon every soul, and many wonders and signs were done through the apostles. 44 Now all who believed were together, and had all things in common, 45 and sold their possessions and goods, and divided them among all, as anyone had need.*

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(Talk about the difficulty of communicating announcements through announcements, mass texting, and email blasts – Angel Food \$60.00 worth of food for \$20.00)

Small groups are the perfect place to develop, communicate and carry out the three verbs of the CT vision:

- Disciple...
- Empower...
- Serve...

In the context of the larger church body we all have an area of giftedness. Romans 12:6-8

(NKJV) “Having then gifts differing according to the grace that is given to us, let us use them: if prophecy, let us prophesy in proportion to our faith; 7 or ministry, let us use it in our ministering; he who teaches, in teaching; 8 he who exhorts, in exhortation; he who gives, with liberality; he who leads, with diligence; he who shows mercy, with cheerfulness.”

Each person’s giftedness should be utilized and maximized. This is very difficult to do in the corporate worship and instruction setting. When the church is broken down into bite sized pieces more people can contribute and utilize their gifts and the church is made healthier because more gifts are functioning as we endeavor to disciple, and empower each believer and we serve one another and the greater good of our community. {Illustration Mental Visual: The body and its various parts and their importance}

The ease with which the church can expand through small groups is exponentially better than the corporate model.

For the first-century Christians “church” meant “house.” Perhaps one of the reasons for the rapid advancement of the gospel was that the model was not just a few clergymen preaching in pulpits, it was groups of Christians growing and developing in their gifts together.

Christian community is not something new it is simply sharing a common life in Christ. Life groups are intended to move us beyond the self-interested isolation of our private lives and challenges us instead to commit ourselves to do life together as the people of God.

We know all too well that maturity takes time. We know less well that it also takes our sisters and brothers in Christ. It’s a process that is revealed in the "each other" language of the

New Testament. Healthy life groups will teach us to:

- Love one another...
- Forgive each other...
- Pray for each other...
- Serve each other...
- Submit to each other...
- Bear one another's burdens...
- Regard each other more highly...
- Teach and correct each other
- Become an encouragement to each other...

Christian Community (Common unity) is more easily developed in small groups. Christian community is:

- A way to see Christ in others...
- A source of accountability and guidance...
- A place to pray and worship... (It will not be another church service)
- A place to serve...

- A witness to the world... (*All men will know you have passed from death to life because you love one another*)

APPLICATION

Doing life with my fellow believers in the context of a life group allows me to:

- Better see Christ in others...
- Have more accountability and guidance...
- Pray and worship in a more intimate setting...
- Serve my brothers and sisters in a more personal way...
- Be less intimidated to invite the un-churched and the de-churched...